

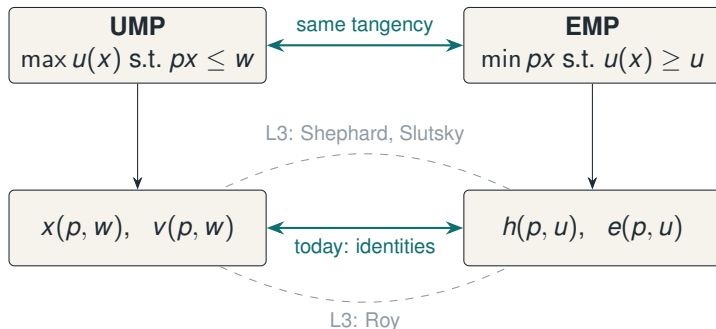
Lecture 2 · Classical Demand I

MWG Ch. 3.A–3.E · two problems, four objects, one square

Advanced Microeconomics 1

Thursday 24 September

The map for the next two lectures



- Today: build all four corners and connect them by *level* identities. L3: connect by *derivatives*. L4: run the arrows backwards (integrability) and cash out (welfare).

Preference axioms for markets

Desirability

Throughout Ch. 3: $X = \mathbb{R}_+^L$, $\succsim$ rational. Add structure:

Definition · desirability axioms

- **Monotone:** $y \gg x \Rightarrow y \succ x$. **Strongly monotone:** $y \geq x$, $y \neq x \Rightarrow y \succ x$.
- **Locally nonsatiated (LNS):** for every x and $\varepsilon > 0$ there is y with $\|y - x\| < \varepsilon$ and $y \succ x$.
- LNS is the weakest and the workhorse: it allows bads and thick regions of indifference in some directions, but rules out *thick indifference sets* — and it is exactly what delivers Walras' law.
- Hierarchy: strongly monotone $\Rightarrow$ monotone $\Rightarrow$ LNS.

Convexity

Definition · convexity

$\succsim$ is **convex** if the upper contour set $\{y : y \succsim x\}$ is convex for every x ; **strictly convex** if $y \succsim x, z \succsim x, y \neq z$ imply $\alpha y + (1 - \alpha)z \succ x$ for $\alpha \in (0, 1)$.

- Interpretations: diminishing marginal rates of substitution; a taste for diversification (averages beat extremes among acceptable bundles).
- What it buys downstream: convex-valued demand; strict convexity $\Rightarrow$ single-valued, hence *functions* rather than correspondences.
- Honest note: convexity is an assumption of convenience. Nothing in “rationality” requires it; nonconvex tastes (specialization, addiction thresholds) simply produce jumpy demand.

Two families you will use constantly

Homothetic

Indifference sets are radial blow-ups:
 $x \sim y \Rightarrow \alpha x \sim \alpha y$. Representable by a u.h.d.1 utility.

Buys: linear wealth expansion paths,
 $x(p, w) = w \cdot x(p, 1)$ — the aggregation-friendly case (Gorman, EC2).

Quasilinear (in good 1)

$x \sim y \Rightarrow x + \alpha e_1 \sim y + \alpha e_1$; representable as $u(x) = x_1 + \phi(x_2, \dots, x_L)$.

Buys: zero wealth effects on goods $2, \dots, L$; $CV = EV =$ consumer surplus — the welfare-friendly case (L5).

- Pattern: special preference classes are not curiosities; each one *switches off* a complication (wealth effects, distribution dependence) so a particular application becomes exact.

Continuity and Debreu's theorem

Definition · continuity

$\succsim$ is continuous if it is preserved under limits: for any sequences $x^n \rightarrow x$, $y^n \rightarrow y$ with $x^n \succsim y^n$ for all n , we have $x \succsim y$. (Equivalently: upper and lower contour sets are closed.)

Proposition · existence (MWG 3.C.1)

If $\succsim$ is rational and continuous on $X = \mathbb{R}_+^L$, it is represented by a *continuous* utility function.

- The counterexample continuity excludes: **lexicographic** preferences. Rational, strongly monotone — but each x_1 -value would need its own non-degenerate utility interval, and $\mathbb{R}$ has only countably many disjoint ones. No representation exists.

The one-slide construction (monotone case)

Assume $\succsim$ also monotone; let $e = (1, \dots, 1)$.

1. For each x , the sets

$$A^+ = \{\alpha \geq 0 : \alpha e \succsim x\} \text{ and}$$

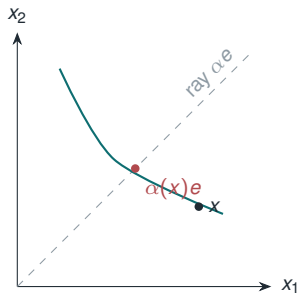
$A^- = \{\alpha \geq 0 : x \succsim \alpha e\}$ are closed
(continuity), nonempty, and cover $\mathbb{R}_+$
(completeness).

2. $\mathbb{R}_+$ connected $\Rightarrow$ they intersect: some $\alpha(x)$
has $\alpha(x)e \sim x$. Monotonicity makes it
unique.

3. Set $u(x) = \alpha(x)$: then

$$x \succsim y \iff \alpha(x) \geq \alpha(y). \quad \square$$

- Measure each bundle by *how far up the diagonal its indifference curve crosses*.
Elegant, constructive, and the template for money-metric utility later.



Dictionary: preference properties $\leftrightarrow$ utility properties

$\succsim \dots$	any representing u is ...
monotone	nondecreasing (increasing if strongly monotone)
convex	quasiconcave
strictly convex	strictly quasiconcave
homothetic	has an h.d.1 representation
quasilinear in good 1	has a $u = x_1 + \phi(x_{-1})$ representation

- **Quasiconcavity, not concavity**: convex preferences pin down only the shape of level sets, and quasiconcavity is the ordinal (transformation-proof) notion. Concavity of u is a cardinal statement — meaningless until Ch. 6.

The Utility Maximization Problem

UMP: statement and existence

UMP

$$\max_{x \in \mathbb{R}_+^L} u(x) \quad \text{s.t.} \quad p \cdot x \leq w, \quad p \gg 0.$$

Solution set: **Walrasian demand** $x(p, w)$; value: **indirect utility** $v(p, w)$.

- Existence: $B_{p,w}$ is compact ($p \gg 0$ does the work), u continuous $\Rightarrow$ Weierstrass. Note existence needs *no* convexity.
- This is the same object as Ch. 2's $x(p, w)$ — but now derived, so its properties come with reasons attached.

First-order conditions

With u differentiable, Kuhn–Tucker at an optimum x^* : there is $\lambda \geq 0$ with

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial x_\ell}(x^*) \leq \lambda p_\ell, \quad \text{with equality if } x_\ell^* > 0.$$

- Interior solution: for any two goods consumed, $\text{MRS}_{\ell k} = \frac{\partial u / \partial x_\ell}{\partial u / \partial x_k} = \frac{p_\ell}{p_k}$ — the tangency picture.
- Corner: $\text{MRS} \leq$ price ratio can hold with strict inequality for unconsumed goods. *Always check corners in problem sets; graders always put one in.*
- λ = marginal utility of wealth: $\lambda = \partial v / \partial w$ (envelope — proved properly next lecture).
- FOCs are sufficient as well as necessary when u is quasiconcave with $\nabla u \neq 0$ (LNS).

Properties of Walrasian demand

Proposition · MWG 3.D.2

If u is continuous and represents LNS $\succsim$, then $x(p, w)$ satisfies:

1. **Homogeneity of degree 0** in (p, w) [budget set unchanged]
2. **Walras' law**: $p \cdot x = w$ for all $x \in x(p, w)$ [LNS: money left over $\Rightarrow$ better bundle nearby]
3. If $\succsim$ convex: $x(p, w)$ convex-valued; if strictly convex: **single-valued**.

- Note the bookkeeping: each Ch. 2 *assumption* is now a *theorem*, with a named axiom responsible. This is what the preference route buys: traceability.

Worked example: Cobb–Douglas (memorize the whole row)

$$u(x) = x_1^\alpha x_2^{1-\alpha}, \alpha \in (0, 1):$$

$$x_1(p, w) = \frac{\alpha w}{p_1}, \quad x_2(p, w) = \frac{(1 - \alpha)w}{p_2} \quad (\text{constant expenditure shares})$$

$$v(p, w) = w \alpha^\alpha (1 - \alpha)^{1-\alpha} p_1^{-\alpha} p_2^{-(1-\alpha)}$$

- Sanity checks to run every time: h.d.0 in (p, w) ? Walras' law? v increasing in w , decreasing in p ?
- Cobb–Douglas is the special case where income and substitution effects on cross-demands exactly cancel ($\partial x_1 / \partial p_2 = 0$) — convenient, and dangerously unrepresentative. CES (later today) is the honest laboratory.

Proposition · MWG 3.D.3

$v(p, w)$ is: (i) h.d.0; (ii) strictly increasing in w , nonincreasing in each p_ℓ ; (iii) continuous; (iv) **quasiconvex**: $\{(p, w) : v(p, w) \leq \bar{v}\}$ is convex.

- Quasiconvexity is the surprising one. Intuition: fix the optimal bundle $\bar{x}$ at (p, w) . Averaging two price–wealth situations that each leave the consumer no better than $\bar{v}$ cannot open up new opportunities — the averaged budget set is contained in the union’s “convexification” of constraints, not of choices.
- Practical use of v : it is the object welfare analysis differentiates (Roy, L4), and the object applied GE models parameterize.

The Expenditure Minimization Problem

EMP: the dual question

EMP

$$\min_{x \in \mathbb{R}_+^L} p \cdot x \quad \text{s.t.} \quad u(x) \geq u \quad (u > u(0), p \gg 0).$$

Solution set: **Hicksian (compensated) demand** $h(p, u)$; value: **expenditure function** $e(p, u)$.

- Why bother with a problem no consumer solves? Because *welfare questions are expenditure questions*: “how many dollars compensate this price change?” is literally $e(\cdot)$ evaluated twice (L5).
- And because e has better mathematical manners than v (concavity in p) — which is where all the derivative magic comes from.

Properties of Hicksian demand

Proposition · MWG 3.E.3

For continuous u representing LNS $\succsim$: $h(p, u)$ is (i) h.d.0 in p ; (ii) exhausts the constraint: $u(x) = u$ for $x \in h(p, u)$ (“no excess utility”); (iii) convex-/single-valued under convexity/strict convexity.

Proposition · compensated law of demand — now for free

For any p', p'' : $(p'' - p') \cdot [h(p'', u) - h(p', u)] \leq 0$.

Two-line proof. $h(p'', u)$ minimizes cost at p'' among bundles reaching u , and $h(p', u)$ is such a bundle: $p'' h(p'', u) \leq p'' h(p', u)$. Symmetrically at p' . Add. $\square$

- Own-price Hicksian demand **never slopes up**: Giffen behavior is an income effect wearing a costume. No compensation subtlety needed here — unlike Ch. 2.

The expenditure function

Proposition · MWG 3.E.2

$e(p, u)$ is: (i) h.d.1 in p ; (ii) strictly increasing in u , nondecreasing in each p_ℓ ; (iii) continuous; (iv) **concave in p** .

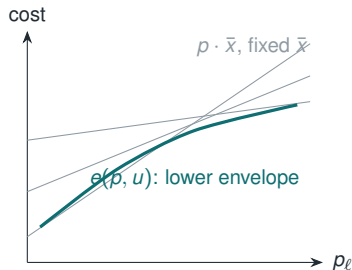
Concavity, the proof to internalize. Fix u ; take $p^\alpha = \alpha p' + (1 - \alpha)p''$ and let $x^\alpha \in h(p^\alpha, u)$. Then

$$e(p^\alpha, u) = \alpha p' x^\alpha + (1 - \alpha) p'' x^\alpha \geq \alpha e(p', u) + (1 - \alpha) e(p'', u),$$

since x^α is feasible (reaches u) at both p' and p'' but not necessarily optimal. $\square$

Why concavity: the envelope-of-lines picture

- For each *fixed* bundle x with $u(x) \geq u$, the map $p \mapsto p \cdot x$ is **linear**.
- $e(\cdot, u)$ is the **pointwise minimum** over all these linear functions — a lower envelope of hyperplanes. Lower envelopes of linear functions are concave. Always.
- Economic content: a *passive* consumer (fixed bundle) has linear costs; *re-optimization* can only help as prices move away — bending the true cost *below* the tangent line.



One trick, three functions

Connecting the corners: the duality identities

Proposition · MWG 3.E.1 and companions

Under LNS and continuity, for $p \gg 0$, $w > 0$, attainable u :

$$\begin{aligned} e(p, v(p, w)) &= w, & v(p, e(p, u)) &= u, \\ h(p, u) &= x(p, e(p, u)), & x(p, w) &= h(p, v(p, w)). \end{aligned}$$

- Same tangency, two descriptions: UMP fixes the budget and finds the highest indifference curve; EMP fixes the indifference curve and finds the lowest budget. LNS guarantees neither problem leaves slack.
- These four identities are the **workhorse of every derivation in L4**: Slutsky is literally “differentiate the third one.”

The CES laboratory (two goods)

$u(x) = (x_1^\rho + x_2^\rho)^{1/\rho}$, $\rho < 1$, $\rho \neq 0$; elasticity of substitution $\sigma = 1/(1 - \rho)$. Define the price index $P \equiv (p_1^{1-\sigma} + p_2^{1-\sigma})^{1/(1-\sigma)}$.

Walrasian demand	$x_\ell(p, w) = \frac{p_\ell^{-\sigma}}{P^{1-\sigma}} w$
Indirect utility	$v(p, w) = w/P$
Expenditure	$e(p, u) = u \cdot P$
Hicksian demand	$h_\ell(p, u) = u \cdot p_\ell^{-\sigma} P^\sigma$

- Limits: $\sigma \rightarrow 1$ Cobb–Douglas; $\sigma \rightarrow 0$ Leontief; $\sigma \rightarrow \infty$ linear. PS1 has you verify every duality identity on this family — do it once by hand, and L4 will feel inevitable.

Takeaways and readings

Takeaways

- Continuity (not rationality) is what buys a utility representation; convexity buys well-behaved demand; LNS buys Walras' law.
- Four objects — x , v , h , e — linked by level identities; e is concave in p by the envelope-of-lines argument.
- Hicksian demand obeys the law of demand unconditionally; Giffen is an income effect.

Required: MWG 3.A–3.E. **Next:** 3.F–3.G before Thursday.

The practical is a week today: all it needs is a laptop with a working R installation — check yours starts now, not the morning of.